Keep clients paying (and sending you friends)

Landing a client is half the job. The monthly fee is what makes this a business, and a happy client is your best source of the next one.

Why small businesses drop their marketing person

In vcita's 2025 survey of 500 US small businesses, 40% of those that outsource marketing ended up dropping or switching their agency, and the #1 reason (60%) was no return on investment. Most of that churn happened in the first 6 to 12 months. Practitioners add two more: feeling like they have to chase you for small things, and budget cuts in a slow season. So: make the work visible, answer fast, and give them options before they leave.

What the monthly fee should cover (and why it's worth it)

- **New pages** for the services and towns they want more of.
- **The Google Business Profile:** weekly posts, fresh photos, services and hours up to date.
- **Reviews, every month.** BrightLocal's 2026 survey: 47% of consumers won't use a business with fewer than 20 reviews, and 74% look for reviews from the last three months. A steady trickle of new reviews is one of the easiest wins you can deliver.
- **Being findable in AI answers.** 45% of consumers used ChatGPT or other AI tools for local recommendations in 2026, up from 6% a year earlier (BrightLocal). Consistent business info, real FAQs and clear service pages help.
- **Fixes** within a day: a broken form, wrong hours, a new phone number.
- **A one-page report.**

The one-page monthly report

- One honest headline ("12 new pages live, and Google showed you more often than last month").
- 4–5 real numbers vs last month, each with its source: pages published, profile calls, website clicks, form leads, new reviews. If a number went down, say so and say why.
- What you did this month, and the 3 things you'll do next month.
- One suggestion that would help them most.

Send it in the first week of every month with a 3-line message.

The 90-day review (15 minutes)

1. What changed since launch (the numbers).
2. What they want more of now.
3. "Anything you'd change about how we work?"

Then the next 90 days in 3 bullet points.

Ask for referrals at the 3 happiest moments

1. **Launch week:** "So glad you like it. Who else do you know who'd want this?"
2. **Day 30:** after the first calls or leads come in.
3. **After a good report:** "Your profile calls are up this month. If a friend's business could use the same, I'd love an intro."

Make it easy with a text they can forward: *"I used [your name] for our website, worth talking to: [phone]."*

When they want to cancel

Thank them, ask what's behind it, then offer the option that fits: a pause for 1–3 months, the smaller package, or one clear goal for the next 60 days. If they still want to go, hand everything over cleanly (domain, content, access) and leave on good terms. A good goodbye is a future referral.

Sources: vcita SMB marketing survey 2025 (500 US small businesses); BrightLocal Local Consumer Review Survey 2026 (1,002 US adults). Free client-finding skills: github.com/WordRocket/local-client-finder. Results vary.